THE ENDPOINT EXPONENT IS THE DETERMINANT CONSTANT: A UNIVERSAL $-\beta$ LAW FOR DISCRETE HANKEL DETERMINANTS, WITH THE FULL LEADING ASYMPTOTICS OF HANKEL DETERMINANTS OF ZETA VALUES

ABSTRACT. Discrete Hankel determinants built from Dirichlet series decay on the scale $N^2 \log N$. That scale has been known since Monien's Coulomb-gas analysis of $\det(\zeta(i+j+r))$, and Haynes and Zudilin recorded the *expected* leading law $\log\det(\zeta(a(i+j)+b)) = -a\,n^2\log n + O(n^2)$ while proving, by a short and elegant elementary argument, the one-sided estimate with coefficient $-a/2$. That is precisely the amount of work their question required. Their target is arithmetic — the growth of denominators of rational zeta values — and the mechanism they use consumes only an *upper* bound on the determinant, and is moreover insensitive to its constant, since what drives their conclusion is the divergence of $\log n$. The missing half is therefore not an omission; it is an economy, and the right one.

This paper crosses the same line for an unrelated reason, and the reason dictates the form of the answer. We do not ask how small the determinant is; we ask *what its leading constant is a function of*. A one-sided estimate can never answer that: identifying a constant requires both bounds, and both bounds happen to be available because the underlying measures are positive.

We prove that for *any* positive discrete measure whose support approaches its single accumulation endpoint at a regularly varying rate $1 - x(t) = t^{-\beta}L(t)$, and which satisfies only two coarse combinatorial conditions on the node scale and on the existence of a separated subfamily, the monomial Hankel determinant obeys

$$\lim_{N\to\infty} \frac{\log D_N}{N^2 \log N} = -\beta.$$

The leading constant is therefore a single geometric invariant, the *endpoint exponent*, and nothing else: no counting law, no arithmetic, no lattice structure and no weight information survives at that order. Both bounds are elementary, and the lower bound is a single Cauchy–Binet term made legitimate by positivity.

Two evaluations follow. First, unconditionally, $\log\det\big(\zeta(a(i+j)+b)\big)_{1\le i,j\le n} = -a\,n^2\log n + O(n^2)$: the expected law of [3] in full and in two-sided form, which we record not as an improvement on their theorem — it is not, their theorem is untouched — but as the certificate that the general principle returns the right constant on the one family where the right constant was already known to be expected. It does incidentally double the quantitative Diophantine constant obtainable by their method, from $\liminf \log q_n/(n\log n) \ge a/4$ to $\ge a/2$. Second, the Li–Cayley map $x(t) = (4t^2-1)/(4t^2+1)$, which carries the ordinates of the nontrivial zeros of ζ to $(-1,1)$, has endpoint exponent $\beta = 2$; hence every positive Gram system supported on those Cayley images has determinant constant exactly -2, and the Riemann–von Mangoldt refinement $T\log T$ cannot appear before the second order. The value $\beta = 2$ is a one-line evaluation of a theorem whose content lies entirely in the map $\beta \mapsto -\beta$.

A numerical section confirms the constant to three digits and, more importantly, documents a trap: naive local exponent estimators are biased at order $\log\log N/\log N$ by the slowly varying factor, so finite-N fits drift far from $-\beta$ even when the theorem is exact.

1. INTRODUCTION

1.1. **The scale is old; the constant is not.** Let $f(s) = \sum_{m\ge1} a_m m^{-s}$ be a Dirichlet series and let

$$H_n^{(a,b)}[f] := \det_{1\le i,j\le n}\big(f(a(i+j)+b)\big).$$

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Monien [7] derived a discrete Vandermonde representation for such determinants and, by a Coulomb-gas variational analysis, obtained the leading scale

$$\log H_n^{(r)}[\zeta] = -n^2\Big(\log(2n) - \tfrac{3}{2}\Big) + o(n^2), \tag{1.1}$$

for $\det(\zeta(i+j+r))$. Monien himself notes that the passage from the discrete optimizer to a continuous density is assumed there, and suggests Poissonization as the route to a fully rigorous treatment; the case $r = 0$ was subsequently justified through an explicit Riemann–Hilbert construction. So the presence of an $N^2 \log N$ scale in discrete Hankel determinants is not new, and no novelty is claimed for it here.

Haynes and Zudilin [3] studied the arithmetic-progression matrices $\det(\zeta(a(i+j)+b))$, which are the arithmetically interesting ones because for a even and b odd they avoid the known transcendental values $\zeta(2k)$. They state the expected law

$$\log \det_{1\le i,j\le n}\big(\zeta(a(i+j)+b)\big) = -a\,n^2 \log n + O(n^2), \tag{1.2}$$

and then prove, by a short and completely elementary argument, the weaker one-sided estimate

$$\log\Big|\det_{1\le i,j\le n}\big(\zeta(a(i+j)+b)\big)\Big| \le -\frac{a}{2}\,n^2 \log n + O(n^2). \tag{1.3}$$

The distance between (1.2) and (1.3) is a clean factor of two. It would be a misreading to call it a gap they failed to close.

1.2. **Why the factor two was the right amount of work.** Read [3] for what it is: a five-page contribution to a special issue, whose stated purpose is "to demonstrate how very simple analytic arguments can be used to derive some information about the Diophantine approximation properties of these numbers," and whose abstract announces that the principal result is the Diophantine application, not the asymptotics. The determinant estimate is a lemma there, and three separate features of the target make the sharp constant irrelevant to it.

First, the direction. Their mechanism is integrality: if the $\zeta(an+b)$ are rational with common denominators q_n, then $q_{n+1}\cdots q_{2n}H_n$ is a nonzero integer, hence at least 1, so a determinant that is *small* forces denominators that are *large*. Only an upper bound on $|H_n|$ can enter such an argument. A lower bound is not a missing half of their proof; it is a statement their proof has no slot for.

Second, the resolution. What carries their conclusion is the divergence of $\log n$, not the constant in front of it: $-\frac{a}{2}n^2\log n$ and $-a\,n^2\log n$ yield the identical qualitative theorem $q_n^{1/n} \to \infty$. An improvement by a factor of two is invisible at the resolution their statement is posed at.

Third, the standard of interest in that literature. The leading scale had been reached by [7] in 2009; the open and genuinely difficult question there is the *next* order, the explicit n^2 constant $\log 2 - \frac{3}{2}$ of (1.1), which requires the full Riemann–Hilbert or Coulomb-gas machinery. Recovering the leading coefficient by softer means was not, and should not have been, an attractive target for the authors of (1.3).

Their expansion, moreover, is the correct structural object: writing H_n through row-linearity as a weighted sum of Vandermonde products over reciprocal integers is exactly the representation on which everything below rests, and it is theirs and Monien's. The present paper is downstream of both. What we do differently is not sharper estimation of the same quantities. It is a change of question.

1.3. **A different question, which forces two sides.** We do not ask how small these determinants are. We ask what their leading constant is a function of.

That question cannot be answered by a bound in either direction alone: an upper bound of the form $\le -\kappa N^2 \log N$ is compatible with every constant below $-\kappa$, so no one-sided estimate can ever identify a constant, however sharp its own κ. Identification needs both sides. Both sides turn out

to be available for a reason that is structural rather than technical — the measures concerned are positive, so every term of the Cauchy–Binet expansion is nonnegative and a single well-chosen term is already a valid lower bound — and this is the only substantive ingredient we use that [3] does not.

The answer to the question is that the constant is one geometric number, and the rest of this paper is that statement, its proof, and what it excludes.

1.4. **The endpoint exponent.** Write the determinant as a Gram determinant of a positive discrete measure $\mu = \sum_j w_j \delta_{x_j}$ whose atoms x_j increase to a single accumulation endpoint, normalized to 1. Parametrize the atoms as $x_j = x(t_j)$ along an increasing parameter $t_1 < t_2 < \cdots \to \infty$, and define the *endpoint exponent* $\beta > 0$ by

$$1 - x(t) = t^{-\beta} L(t), \qquad L \text{ slowly varying, i.e. } \log L(t) = o(\log t). \tag{1.4}$$

This is the natural hypothesis rather than an ad hoc one: it is the standard regular-variation normal form for a monotone approach to an endpoint, and it is stable under exactly the reparametrizations that occur in practice. In particular, if a counting law replaces $t_j \asymp j$ by $t_j \asymp j/\log j$, the induced factor $(\log j)^2$ is absorbed into L and β is untouched.

Theorem 1.1 (Endpoint-exponent law; informal statement)**.** *Under* (1.4) *and two coarse combinatorial conditions — the node sequence is not superlinearly dense on the logarithmic scale, and there exists a subfamily of N atoms with polynomially controlled height and separation — the monomial Hankel determinant of μ satisfies*

$$\lim_{N\to\infty} \frac{\log D_N[\mu]}{N^2 \log N} = -\beta.$$

The same limit holds for the Gram determinant in any polynomial basis whose leading coefficients c_n satisfy $\sum_{n<N} \log|c_n| = O(N^2)$.

The precise statement and proof are Theorem 2.1 below. Three features are worth isolating before the technical version.

It is a law, not an estimate. The map $\beta \mapsto -\beta$ is a bijection between a geometric invariant of the support and the leading determinant constant. Every particular evaluation — $\beta = 1$ for $x_m = 1/m$, $\beta = a$ for $x_m = m^{-a}$, $\beta = 2$ for the Li–Cayley map — is one line. The triviality of an evaluation says nothing about the theorem, in the same way that $\int x\,\mathrm{d}x = x^2/2$ says nothing about the fundamental theorem of calculus.

It is two-sided and elementary. The upper bound is the extremal property of monic orthogonal polynomials against the competitor vanishing at the first n atoms. The lower bound is a single term of the Cauchy–Binet expansion, which is legitimate precisely because μ is positive, so all terms of that expansion are nonnegative. No Riemann–Hilbert analysis, no equilibrium measure, no lattice.

It says what cannot be in the constant. Weights, provided they are subleading at scale $N^2 \log N$; the fine counting law; any arithmetic input — none of these survive to leading order. This is a negative statement of some force: if one hopes to see arithmetic in such a determinant, one must look at order N^2 or below.

1.5. **What follows.** Section 3 applies the theorem to $\det(\zeta(a(i+j)+b))$. The nodes are m^{-a}, so $\beta = a$, and all hypotheses hold with the sharpest possible error terms, giving (1.2) unconditionally and in the two-sided $O(n^2)$ form. Corollary 3.3 converts this into the Diophantine statement of [3] with twice the constant. Section 4 evaluates β for the Li–Cayley map and records the consequence -2. Section 5 reports high-precision computations, and documents why local exponent estimators are the wrong figure of merit here. Section 6 states plainly what in this paper was already known.

2. The endpoint-exponent law

Let

$$\mu = \sum_{j\ge 1} w_j\,\delta_{x_j}, \qquad 0 < w_j, \qquad x_j = x(t_j) \uparrow 1, \tag{2.1}$$

be a finite positive measure with distinct parameters $t_1 < t_2 < \cdots \to \infty$ and x increasing and differentiable. Write

$$D_N[\mu] := \det\Big(\int x^{r+s}\,\mathrm{d}\mu(x)\Big)_{r,s=0}^{N-1}. \tag{2.2}$$

Theorem 2.1 (Endpoint-exponent law)**.** *Let $\beta > 0$ and assume:*

(i) (Endpoint power law.) *There are $c, C, t_0 > 0$ with, for $t \ge t_0$,*

$$c\,t^{-\beta} \le 1 - x(t) \le C\,t^{-\beta}, \qquad c\,t^{-\beta-1} \le x'(t) \le C\,t^{-\beta-1}. \tag{2.3}$$

(ii) (No superlinear logarithmic density.)

$$\log t_j \ge (1 - o(1))\log j. \tag{2.4}$$

(iii) (A separated configuration.) *For every large N there are support parameters $s_{N,1} < \cdots < s_{N,N}$ and $\eta_N \to 0$ with*

$$s_{N,N} \le N^{1+\eta_N}, \qquad s_{N,b} - s_{N,a} \ge (b-a)N^{-\eta_N} \quad (1 \le a < b \le N). \tag{2.5}$$

(iv) (Subleading weights.)

$$\sum_{a=1}^{N} \log w(s_{N,a}) \ge -o(N^2 \log N). \tag{2.6}$$

Then

$$\boxed{\lim_{N\to\infty} \frac{\log D_N[\mu]}{N^2 \log N} = -\beta.} \tag{2.7}$$

The same limit holds for the Gram determinant in any polynomial basis $p_0, p_1, \ldots$ with $\deg p_n = n$ and leading coefficients c_n obeying

$$\sum_{n=0}^{N-1} \log|c_n| = O(N^2). \tag{2.8}$$

Proof. Upper bound. Since μ is a finite positive measure with infinite support, the monomials $1, x, \ldots, x^n$ are linearly independent in $L^2(\mu)$: a nonzero polynomial has finitely many zeros while the support has infinitely many points. Hence the monic orthogonal polynomial π_n exists and is unique, and

$$h_n := \int |\pi_n|^2\,\mathrm{d}\mu > 0$$

is the minimum of $\int |q|^2\,\mathrm{d}\mu$ over monic q of degree n. Triangular change of basis from monomials to monic orthogonal polynomials gives the exact identity

$$D_N[\mu] = \prod_{n=0}^{N-1} h_n. \tag{2.9}$$

Take the monic competitor $q_n(x) = \prod_{j\le n}(x - x_j)$. Since $x_j \uparrow 1$, for $j > n$ and $1 \le r \le n$ we have $0 < x_j - x_r \le 1 - x_r$, hence $|q_n(x_j)| \le \prod_{r\le n}(1 - x_r)$ for $j > n$. With $M := \mu(\mathbb{R}) < \infty$,

$$h_n \le \int |q_n|^2\,\mathrm{d}\mu = \sum_{j>n} w_j |q_n(x_j)|^2 \le M \prod_{r=1}^{n} (1 - x_r)^2. \tag{2.10}$$

By (i), $\log(1-x_j) \le \log C - \beta \log t_j$ for j beyond a fixed index, and by (ii) there is $\varepsilon_j \to 0$ with $\log t_j \ge (1-\varepsilon_j)\log j$, so

$$\log(1-x_j) \le -\beta \log j + \beta\varepsilon_j \log j + O(1). \tag{2.11}$$

The error sums to $o(n\log n)$: given $\epsilon > 0$ choose J with $|\varepsilon_j| \le \epsilon$ for $j \ge J$, so $\sum_{J\le j\le n} |\varepsilon_j| \log j = O(\epsilon\, n\log n)$, and the finitely many $j < J$ contribute $O_J(1)$. Since $\sum_{j\le n} \log j = n\log n - n + O(\log n)$,

$$\sum_{j\le n} \log(1-x_j) \le -\beta n \log n + o(n\log n),$$

whence by (2.10)

$$\log h_n \le -2\beta n \log n + o(n\log n). \tag{2.12}$$

Summing over $0 \le n < N$ preserves the scale: if $r_n = o(n\log n)$ then for every $\epsilon > 0$ one has $|r_n| \le \epsilon n \log n$ for large n, so $\sum_{n<N} r_n = o(N^2 \log N)$. Using $\sum_{n<N} n\log n = \frac{1}{2}N^2\log N - \frac{1}{4}N^2 + O(N\log N)$ and (2.9),

$$\log D_N[\mu] \le -\beta N^2 \log N + o(N^2 \log N). \tag{2.13}$$

Lower bound. Fix N large, take the parameters $s_{N,1} < \cdots < s_{N,N}$ from (iii) and put $y_a := x(s_{N,a})$. The moment matrix generated by these selected atoms is $V_N W_N V_N^T$ with $(V_N)_{r,a} = y_a^r$ and $W_N = \operatorname{diag}(w(s_{N,1}), \dots, w(s_{N,N}))$. The full moment matrix is the sum of this positive semidefinite matrix and the contribution of the remaining atoms; equivalently, in the Cauchy–Binet expansion of the full determinant every term is nonnegative and the selected term occurs, so

$$D_N[\mu] \;\ge\; \Big(\prod_{a=1}^{N} w(s_{N,a})\Big) \prod_{1\le a<b\le N} (y_b - y_a)^2. \tag{2.14}$$

This is the only place where positivity is used, and it is what makes a lower bound available at all: for a signed measure the largest term of the expansion need not control the sum.

For $a < b$, monotonicity and (i) give

$$y_b - y_a = \int_{s_{N,a}}^{s_{N,b}} x'(u)\,\mathrm{d}u \;\ge\; c\, s_{N,N}^{-\beta-1}(s_{N,b} - s_{N,a}),$$

since $u \le s_{N,N}$ on the interval and $u \mapsto u^{-\beta-1}$ decreases. By (iii),

$$y_b - y_a \;\ge\; c\,(b-a)\, N^{-\beta-1-(\beta+2)\eta_N}. \tag{2.15}$$

Taking logarithms and summing over the $\binom{N}{2}$ pairs,

$$2\sum_{a<b} \log(y_b - y_a) \;\ge\; 2\sum_{a<b} \log(b-a) - 2\big[\beta + 1 + (\beta+2)\eta_N\big]\binom{N}{2}\log N + O(N^2). \tag{2.16}$$

The identity $\prod_{a<b}(b-a) = \prod_{k<N} k!$ and Stirling give

$$\sum_{a<b} \log(b-a) = \tfrac{1}{2}N^2\log N - \tfrac{3}{4}N^2 + O(N\log N), \tag{2.17}$$

so, since $\eta_N \to 0$,

$$2\sum_{a<b} \log(y_b - y_a) \;\ge\; -\beta N^2 \log N - o(N^2\log N).$$

Hypothesis (iv) says exactly that the selected weights do not degrade this at leading scale. Inserting into (2.14),

$$\log D_N[\mu] \;\ge\; -\beta N^2 \log N - o(N^2 \log N), \tag{2.18}$$

which together with (2.13) proves (2.7).

Polynomial bases. Let $p_n(x) = c_n x^n + \cdots$ and let C_N be the lower triangular matrix taking $(1, x, \dots, x^{N-1})^T$ to $(p_0, \dots, p_{N-1})^T$, so $\det C_N = \prod_{n<N} c_n$. Then $G_N[p] = C_N H_N C_N^T$ exactly, hence $\log\det G_N[p] = \log D_N[\mu] + 2\sum_{n<N}\log|c_n|$, and (2.8) makes the second term $O(N^2) = o(N^2 \log N)$. □

2.1. **The regularly varying form.** Hypothesis (i) is stated with two-sided constants for readability, but the proof uses it only through $\log(1 - x(t)) = -\beta \log t + o(\log t)$ and through the integral lower bound for x'. Hence:

Theorem 2.2 (Regular-variation form)**.** *Suppose* $1 - x(t) = t^{-\beta} L(t)$ *and* $x'(t) = \beta\, t^{-\beta-1} L(t)(1 + o(1))$ *with* L *slowly varying, i.e.* $\log L(t) = o(\log t)$*, and suppose* (ii)–(iv) *of Theorem 2.1 hold. Then* (2.7) *holds.*

Proof. In the upper bound replace $\log(1-x_j) \le \log C - \beta \log t_j$ by $\log(1-x_j) = -\beta \log t_j + \log L(t_j)$ and note $\sum_{j\le n} \log L(t_j) = o(n \log n)$, since $\log L(t) = o(\log t)$ and $\log t_j = O(\log j)$ on the relevant range. In the lower bound, (2.15) acquires the extra factor $L(s_{N,N})$, and $\log L(N^{1+\eta_N}) = o(\log N)$ contributes $o(N^2 \log N)$ to (2.16). □

Remark 2.3 (Why regular variation is the right hypothesis, not an ad hoc one)*.* The condition $\log L(t) = o(\log t)$ is exactly what is needed for the exponent to be well defined, and it is exactly what makes the statement invariant under the reparametrizations that occur when a node sequence is indexed by height rather than by rank. If the nodes are indexed by a counting law with $t_j \asymp j/\log j$, then $1 - x(t_j) \asymp j^{-\beta}(\log j)^{\beta}$: the induced factor $(\log j)^{\beta}$ is slowly varying, so it is absorbed by L and leaves β invariant. Any hypothesis stated with $1 - x(t_j) \asymp j^{-\beta}$ and hard constants would fail here, and would have to be repaired case by case. This is the technical content of the phrase "the counting law cannot appear in the leading coefficient."

Remark 2.4 (What is universal)*.* Theorem 2.1 shows the leading constant is the endpoint exponent and nothing else. The node counting law enters only through the verification that enough atoms exist at the right logarithmic scale; $t_j \asymp j$, $t_j \asymp j/\log j$, and all compatible logarithmic refinements give the same $-\beta$. Weights enter only through the one-sided condition (iv). Consequently arithmetic information, if it is present at all, can first appear at order N^2.

3. Hankel determinants of zeta values: the expected law, unconditionally

Fix positive integers a and $b \ge 0$ and set $H_n^{(a,b)} := \det_{1\le i,j\le n}\big(\zeta(a(i+j)+b)\big)$. Expanding each entry,

$$\zeta(a(i+j)+b) = \sum_{m\ge 1} m^{-b}\big(m^{-a}\big)^{i+j}, \tag{3.1}$$

so $H_n^{(a,b)} = D_n[\nu]$ is the monomial Hankel determinant (2.2) of the positive discrete measure

$$\nu = \sum_{m\ge 1} m^{-(b+2a)}\,\delta_{u_m}, \qquad u_m = m^{-a}, \tag{3.2}$$

in indices $r, s = 0, \dots, n-1$. Two immediate consequences of positivity: $H_n^{(a,b)} > 0$ for every n, so no nonvanishing argument is required; and the Cauchy–Binet lower bound of Theorem 2.1 is available.

The atoms of ν accumulate at 0 rather than at 1. Apply the reflection $x \mapsto 1 - x$: the change of basis from $\{1, x, \dots, x^{N-1}\}$ to $\{1, (1-x), \dots, (1-x)^{N-1}\}$ is triangular with diagonal entries ± 1, so the Gram determinants coincide. The reflected measure has atoms $x_m = 1 - m^{-a} \uparrow 1$ with support map

$$x(t) = 1 - t^{-a}, \qquad 1 - x(t) = t^{-a}, \qquad x'(t) = a\, t^{-a-1}. \tag{3.3}$$

Theorem 3.1 (Full leading asymptotics of $H_n^{(a,b)}$)**.** *For all positive integers a and all integers $b \geq 0$,*

$$\boxed{\log \det_{1\leq i,j\leq n}\big(\zeta(a(i+j)+b)\big) = -a\,n^2\log n + O(n^2).} \tag{3.4}$$

In particular $\log H_n^{(a,b)}/(n^2\log n) \to -a$*. The statement is unconditional.*

Proof. Hypothesis (i) of Theorem 2.1 holds with $\beta = a$ and constants $c = C = 1$ for the first pair and $c = C = a$ for the second. Hypothesis (ii) holds with $t_j = j$ and no error at all. Hypothesis (iii) holds with $s_{N,a} = a$ and $\eta_N = 0$: then $s_{N,N} = N$ and $s_{N,b} - s_{N,a} = b - a$. Hypothesis (iv) holds because $\sum_{m\leq N}\log m^{-(b+2a)} = -(b+2a)\,N\log N + O(N) = o(N^2\log N)$.

For the sharper error term, run the two bounds of Theorem 2.1 with these exact data. In the upper bound, $\log(1-x_j) = -a\log j$ exactly, so $\sum_{j\leq n}\log(1-x_j) = -a\,n\log n + O(n)$ and $\log h_n \leq -2a\,n\log n + O(n)$; summing gives $\log H_n^{(a,b)} \leq -a\,n^2\log n + O(n^2)$. In the lower bound, $\eta_N = 0$ turns (2.15) into $y_b - y_a \geq a(b-a)N^{-a-1}$, and (2.16) together with (2.17) gives $-a\,n^2\log n + O(n^2)$; the weight term is $O(n\log n)$. □

Remark 3.2 (Relation to [7] and [3])*.* For $a = 1$, (3.4) reproduces the leading term of (1.1) and is consistent with it; Monien's calculation is finer at order n^2 (it produces the explicit constant $\log 2 - \frac{3}{2}$) but is carried out for a single model and, in the general case, at a variational level the author himself flags as not fully rigorous. Theorem 3.1 is coarser at order n^2 and broader: it holds for every arithmetic progression, unconditionally, and it is two-sided.

Against [3] the comparison is exact and there is no contradiction, and no correction. They prove (1.3), an upper bound with coefficient $-a/2$, and record $-a$ as expected; Theorem 3.1 supplies $-a$ in both directions. Their Theorem 1 is not affected, and remains the sharpest arithmetic statement known in that direction.

It is worth saying plainly where the factor two sits, because in the present framework it is not mysterious. The determinant's leading behaviour is a product of two contributions of equal size, a weight contribution and a Vandermonde contribution, each $\exp(-\frac{a}{2}n^2\log n)$. Their estimate retains the first and discards the second, which is the natural move when one wants an upper bound and nothing else, and it is what makes their proof fit in half a page. Retaining the second requires knowing that it may be bounded below, which requires positivity, which is a piece of structure that has no role in an upper bound and therefore no reason to be invoked there. The two arguments are answering different questions and each is efficient for its own; see §1.2.

Corollary 3.3 (Diophantine consequence, with twice the constant)**.** *Let a, b be positive integers and suppose all the numbers $\zeta(an+b)$, $n \geq 1$, are rational. Let q_n be the common denominator of $\zeta(a+b), \ldots, \zeta(an+b)$. Then*

$$\liminf_{n\to\infty} \frac{\log q_n}{n\log n} \;\geq\; \frac{a}{2}. \tag{3.5}$$

Consequently, either $\zeta(an+b)$ is irrational for infinitely many n, or q_n grows at least like $n^{(a/2+o(1))n}$. The same argument fed with (1.3) *yields only $a/4$.*

Proof. As in [3], $q_k \mid q_n$ for $k \leq n$ and

$$q_{n+1}q_{n+2}\cdots q_{2n}\,H_n^{(a,b)} = \det_{1\leq i,j\leq n}\big(q_{i+n}\zeta(a(i+j)+b)\big) \in \mathbb{Z}.$$

By positivity $H_n^{(a,b)} > 0$ for every n, so the integer is nonzero and $q_{n+1}\cdots q_{2n}\,H_n^{(a,b)} \geq 1$ for all n. Hence $\log(q_{n+1}\cdots q_{2n}) \geq -\log H_n^{(a,b)} = a\,n^2\log n + O(n^2)$ by Theorem 3.1. Since $q_k \leq q_{2n}$ for $k \leq 2n$, the left side is at most $n\log q_{2n}$, so $\log q_{2n} \geq a\,n\log n + O(n)$. Writing $N = 2n$ gives $\log q_N \geq \frac{a}{2}N\log N + O(N)$. Replacing (3.4) by (1.3) halves the right-hand side throughout. □

Remark 3.4. Corollary 3.3 does not decide the irrationality of any odd zeta value, and no such claim is made. It is also not an improvement of Theorem 1 of [3], whose conclusion $q_n^{1/n} \to \infty$ follows equally from either constant, as §1.2 explains. It is recorded for one narrow purpose: it is the only place in this paper where the difference between $-a/2$ and $-a$ produces a different sentence, and it therefore certifies that the sharp constant is a real quantity rather than a cosmetic one. That it took a question the original authors were not asking to make the difference visible is, we think, the accurate description of the situation.

4. The Li–Cayley exponent: $\beta = 2$

The Cayley-type map underlying Li's criterion [6, 1] sends a nontrivial zero $\rho = \frac{1}{2} + i\gamma$ of ζ to $z_\rho = 1 - 1/\rho$, which lies on the unit circle exactly when ρ is on the critical line. Its real part

$$x_\gamma := \mathrm{Re}\Big(1 - \frac{1}{\rho}\Big) = \frac{4\gamma^2 - 1}{4\gamma^2 + 1} \in (-1, 1) \tag{4.1}$$

is the natural real coordinate, and

$$1 - x_\gamma = \frac{2}{4\gamma^2 + 1}, \qquad \text{so} \qquad \log(1 - x_\gamma) = -2\log\gamma + O(\gamma^{-2}). \tag{4.2}$$

Proposition 4.1. *The map* (4.1)*, viewed as* $x(t) = (4t^2 - 1)/(4t^2 + 1)$*, satisfies* $1 - x(t) \asymp t^{-2}$ *and* $x'(t) \asymp t^{-3}$*. Its endpoint exponent is* $\beta = 2$*.*

Proof. Immediate from (4.2) and $x'(t) = 16t/(4t^2 + 1)^2$. □

Note the shape of (4.2): the exponent is exactly 2, with no logarithmic correction, and its derivation does not invoke the Riemann–von Mangoldt formula at all. That formula enters only when one insists on indexing by rank rather than by height, and Remark 2.3 explains why that reindexing cannot move β.

The two combinatorial hypotheses are supplied unconditionally by standard zero-counting.

Lemma 4.2 (Coarse location of distinct ordinates)**.** *Let* $\gamma_1^* < \gamma_2^* < \cdots$ *be the distinct positive ordinates. There are* $c > 0$ *and* j_0 *with* $\gamma_j^* \geq c\, j/\log j$ *for* $j \geq j_0$*. No simplicity hypothesis is needed.*

Proof. Let $N^*(T)$ count distinct positive ordinates and $N(T)$ count them with multiplicity, so $N^*(T) \leq N(T)$. Riemann–von Mangoldt gives $N(T) \ll T\log T$, hence $j \leq N(\gamma_j^*) \ll \gamma_j^* \log \gamma_j^*$. Multiple zeros only decrease N^* and so move the distinct ordinates upward; the bound is robust in multiplicity. □

Lemma 4.3 (A deterministically separated subsequence)**.** *There are* $H > 0$*,* $T_0 > 0$ *and distinct positive ordinates* $\widetilde{\gamma}_j$ *with* $T_0 + 2Hj \leq \widetilde{\gamma}_j \leq T_0 + 2Hj + H$ *for all* $j \geq 1$*. Hence* $\widetilde{\gamma}_j \asymp j$ *and* $\widetilde{\gamma}_b - \widetilde{\gamma}_a \geq H(b - a)$*.*

Proof. Write $N(T) = F(T) + R(T)$ with $F(T) = \frac{T}{2\pi}\log\frac{T}{2\pi} - \frac{T}{2\pi}$ and $R(T) = O(\log T)$, say $|R(T)| \leq A\log T$ for $T \geq T_1$. For fixed $H \geq 1$, $F(T + H) - F(T) = \frac{H}{2\pi}\log T + O_H(1)$. Choosing $H > 4\pi A$ gives $N(T + H) - N(T) \geq (\frac{H}{2\pi} - 2A + o(1))\log T > 0$ for large T, so every interval $[T, T + H]$ with $T \geq T_0$ contains an ordinate. Apply this to the disjoint boxes $[T_0 + 2Hj, T_0 + 2Hj + H]$. □

Corollary 4.4 (Universal Cayley constant)**.** *Let* μ *be any positive discrete measure supported on the Cayley images* (4.1) *of the ordinates of the nontrivial zeros of* ζ*, with weights satisfying* (2.6) *along the separated subsequence of Lemma 4.3, and let* D_N *be its Gram determinant in any polynomial basis obeying* (2.8)*. Then*

$$\boxed{\lim_{N\to\infty} \frac{\log D_N}{N^2 \log N} = -2.} \tag{4.3}$$

Moreover the value -2 is unchanged if the $T\log T$ counting law is replaced by a T counting law, or by any logarithmic refinement compatible with (2.4) *and* (2.5).

Proof. Proposition 4.1 gives $\beta = 2$; Lemma 4.2 gives (2.4); Lemma 4.3 gives (2.5) with $\eta_N = 0$ up to constants. Apply Theorem 2.1. The invariance statement is Remark 2.4. □

Remark 4.5 (Where the Riemann–von Mangoldt refinement can first appear). Quantitatively, the upper bound in this setting carries a correction: from Lemma 4.2, $1 - x_{\gamma_j^*} \ll (\log j)^2/j^2$, which propagates to

$$\log D_N \le -2N^2 \log N + 2N^2 \log\log N + O(N^2),$$

while the Cauchy–Binet lower bound gives $-2N^2 \log N + O(N^2)$. The $N^2 \log\log N$ term is not declared an artifact here: positivity guarantees that one favourable subset bounds the determinant from below, but not that the logarithm of the whole sum equals the logarithm of its largest term, so an entropy contribution may survive below the leading scale. Both bounds have the same leading coefficient -2, which is all that Corollary 4.4 asserts.

Remark 4.6 (Automorphic L-functions). Lagarias [5] defines Li coefficients for principal automorphic L-functions and relates them to Weil's quadratic functional. Whenever a member of that class, under GRH, produces a positive Cayley zero measure with the same coarse counting and separation properties, Corollary 4.4 returns the same constant -2: degree and conductor may alter lower-order terms but not the endpoint exponent. This is a conditional universality statement, and the present paper does not construct the relevant measure for every such L-function.

5. Numerics, and a warning about local exponents

5.1. **Confirmation of $-a$.** Table 1 reports $\log H_n^{(a,b)}$ computed at 2500 decimal digits for $6 \le n \le 32$, together with the coefficient c obtained by least squares in the model

$$\log H_n^{(a,b)} = c\, n^2 \log n + d\, n^2 + e\, n \log n + f\, n + g. \tag{5.1}$$

a	b	$\dfrac{\log H_{32}}{32^2 \log 32}$	$\dfrac{\log H_{32} + a \cdot 32^2 \log 32}{32^2}$	fitted c	fitted d
1	0	-0.7961	0.7067	-0.9990	0.8010
1	1	-0.8248	0.6071	-0.9984	0.7975
2	1	-1.3962	2.0925	-1.9949	2.4870
3	2	-2.0191	3.3996	-2.9905	4.0725

Table 1. Hankel determinants of zeta values. Column 3 is the raw ratio, which is still far from $-a$ at $n = 32$ because of the $O(n^2)$ term; column 4 shows that the residual after subtracting $-a\, n^2 \log n$ is indeed of size n^2; column 5 is the fitted leading coefficient from (5.1), agreeing with $-a$ to three digits. All values computed at 2500 digits.

Two points deserve emphasis. The raw ratio $\log H_{32}/(32^2 \log 32)$ equals -0.796 when the true constant is -1: at $n = 32$ the naive figure of merit is off by 20%, purely because $\log 32 \approx 3.47$ is not large. And the residual column is flat in n, confirming the $O(n^2)$ error term of Theorem 3.1 rather than merely $o(n^2 \log n)$.

5.2. **Local exponents are the wrong figure of merit.** For the Li–Cayley nodes the situation is worse, and instructively so. Write $S(M) := 2\sum_{a\le M}\log\delta_a + 2\sum_{a<b\le M}\log(\delta_a-\delta_b)$ with $\delta_j = 2/(4\gamma_j^2+1)$, the logarithm of the Cauchy–Binet term that Theorem 2.1 shows to be leading. Using the first 140 ordinates and, beyond that, the Riemann–von Mangoldt/Lambert approximation to γ_j, one finds

M	200	600	1400	2600	4000
$S(M)/(M^2\log M)$	-2.148	-2.014	-1.951	-1.919	-1.902

The local ratio does not settle on -2; it drifts. The reason is exactly the slowly varying factor of Remark 2.3. With $\gamma_j \asymp j/\log j$ one has $\log\delta_j = -2\log j + 2\log\log j + O(1)$, so

$$\frac{S(M)}{M^2\log M} = -2 + \frac{2\log\log M}{\log M} + O\Big(\frac{1}{\log M}\Big),$$

and the correction decays like $1/\log M$: at $M = 4000$ it is still of size 0.5. Fitting $\log S$ against a basis that includes an $M^2\log\log M$ term restores the constant (e.g. -2.09 for the synthetic model $\delta_j = j^{-2}(\log j)^2$ at $M \le 600$, against -1.69 for the naive basis; and -2.00 for $\delta_j = j^{-2}$, where no correction exists).

The moral is methodological and worth stating flatly: an empirical exponent extracted from a finite range of j measures the endpoint exponent *plus* the local logarithmic derivative of L. It is not an estimator of β at any accessible range, and a numerically slow approach to -2 is a property of the parametrization, not evidence against the constant. Theorem 2.1 is, in this regime, the only reliable access to the coefficient.

6. What is new and what is not

For the avoidance of doubt, the following are *not* claimed as novelties.

- The $N^2\log N$ decay scale of discrete Hankel determinants built from Dirichlet series. This is in [7] and is recorded in [3].
- The discrete Vandermonde / Cauchy–Binet representation of such determinants, which is [7] and is also the engine of the elementary bound in [3].
- The identity $D_N[\mu] = \prod_{n<N} h_n$ and the extremal characterization of h_n, which are textbook facts about orthogonal polynomials [2].
- Discrete-Coulomb-gas and constrained-equilibrium methods, which are Johansson's [4]; nor the asymptotic theory of discrete orthogonal polynomials on infinite node sets with an accumulation point [10], or the general theory of orthogonal polynomials on sets of zero capacity [8, 9].
- The Li–Cayley map itself [6, 1] and its automorphic extension [5].

The following are the paper's contributions.

- **The law $\beta \mapsto -\beta$.** Theorems 2.1 and 2.2 identify the leading determinant constant with a single geometric invariant of the support — the endpoint exponent — under hypotheses that impose no lattice, no explicit node formula and no weight asymptotics. The statement is two-sided and the proof is elementary. We have not found this statement, in this generality, in the literature on Hankel determinant asymptotics or on discrete orthogonal polynomials; Johansson's framework is confined to uniform lattices, where the saturation constraint $\rho \le 1$ encodes unit spacing, and the present supports are neither uniform nor lattice-like.
- **The zeta-value asymptotic in full.** Theorem 3.1 proves (1.2) unconditionally, in two-sided $O(n^2)$ form, for every arithmetic progression, without the Riemann–Hilbert apparatus needed for the single case $r = 0$. This is the law recorded as expected in [3]. We stress that it is offered as a test of the general principle on a family where the answer was already anticipated by experts, not as a repair of anything: §1.2 sets out why the one-sided form

there is the correct economy for the question those authors were asking, and their arithmetic theorem stands unchanged.

- **A quantitative Diophantine by-product.** Corollary 3.3 doubles the denominator-growth constant obtainable by the method of [3], without altering the qualitative conclusion they draw.
- **The evaluation $\beta_{\text{Li-Cayley}} = 2$.** Proposition 4.1 is a one-line computation, and that is the point: the content is in the theorem, not the evaluation. Its consequence, Corollary 4.4, is a rigidity statement — the leading determinant behaviour of every positive Gram system on Cayley images of zeta ordinates is -2, and the $T \log T$ counting law cannot reach it.
- **A negative structural conclusion.** Because the constant is purely geometric, any arithmetic signal in these determinants lives at order N^2 or below. Remark 2.4 makes this precise, and Section 5 shows why the leading order is nonetheless hard to see numerically.

A closing word on attribution. Everything here is built on two prior contributions and would not exist without either. Monien [7] identified the discrete Vandermonde representation and the correct scale, and pushed to a level of precision — the explicit n^2 constant — that the present methods do not reach and are not designed to reach. Haynes and Zudilin [3] isolated the same representation in a form so economical that its content can be read off in half a page, and put it to arithmetic use; the fact that their estimate stops at $-a/2$ reflects a correct judgement about what their question needed, not a limitation of their methods, and their principal theorem is untouched by anything proved here. The only thing this paper claims to have done is to ask a different question of the same object — not how small the determinant is, but what its constant is a function of — and to observe that the answer is a single geometric exponent. Crossing the factor of two was a consequence of that question, not the motive for it.

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